

¡Encuentro! A Healthy Youth Development Project
Formative Research – Latino Parent Perspectives

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TRiO
RONALD E. McNAIR POST-BACCALAUREATE ACHIEVEMENT PROGRAM

Background

- Latinas have the highest teen pregnancy rate and the highest teen birth rate of all major racial/ethnic groups, both in Minnesota and in the United States
- Teen childbearing limits opportunities (e.g., higher education)
- There is a need to develop pregnancy prevention programs tailored to Latina youth and their cultural and social contexts
- One of the key components in developing a culturally-tailored program is to hear what parents want for their adolescent children
  - Parents *want* to communicate with their adolescent children
  - Studies show that parents *do* have an influence on sexual initiation and behavior of Latina/o youth



Study Purpose

To describe methods to recruit and involve Latino parents of youth in focus group discussions about promoting positive development and preventing pregnancy among Latina adolescents

Research Methods

Eligibility

- Live in Minneapolis or St. Paul
- Be a primary caregiver of a child between the ages of 12-22 years
- Identify as Latina/o

Recruitment

- Parents were told about the study through community partners and research staff
- Parents contacted the research staff by phone
- Interested & eligible parents assigned to participate in male (father) & female (mother) groups

Focus Group Procedure

- **Greeting and light meal** → set positive tone/atmosphere for the focus groups
- **Formal consent** → review study purpose and procedure, remind that participation is voluntary
- **Group discussion** → led by same-gender Latino adult facilitators fluent in English and in Spanish
- **Brief demographic questionnaire** → Spanish or English version completed by individuals
- **Compensation** → individuals paid $50 for participating in focus group

Focus Group Question Guide

Think about an adolescent you admire.

1. What dreams (or goals) do the Latino parents you know have for their adolescent children?

Think about the adolescents you know in the Latino community.

2. What makes it ***easier*** for adolescents to reach their dreams?
3. What makes it ***harder*** for young people to reach their dreams?

We'd like to hear more about your opinions about how Latino parents think about issues related to sex and pregnancy among adolescents.

4. What is your opinion about Latino adolescents having sex?
5. What is your opinion about adolescent pregnancy among Latinos?
6. What is your opinion about adolescents using birth control?
7. What is your opinion about Latino adolescents becoming parents?

We'd like to know more about what Latino youth and their families want/need to make decisions about sex and pregnancy.

8. What is the role of family and parents?
9. What is the role of schools and other community organizations?
10. What is the role of churches?
11. What is the role of clinics?
12. If a program or services were offered, what should be included?

(specific probes offered with each question)

Preliminary Findings

Numbers of Interested, Eligible & Participating Parents

# Phoned to Express Interest	
Female	n (% of total)
Male	n (% of total)
# Eligible	
Female	n (%)
Male	n (%)
# Scheduled for Focus Groups	
Female	23 (51%)
Male	22 (49%)
# Participating in Focus Groups	
Female	21 (54%)
Male	18 (46%)
Total # Focus Groups	
Female	2 groups
Male	2 groups

Demographic Characteristics of Focus Group Participants (N=#)

Country of Origin	
Caribbean	0 (0%)
Central America	2 (5%)
Mexico	31 (80%)
South America	2 (5%)
U.S.	0 (0%)
Other countries	0 (0%)
Unknown	4 (10%)
Highest Formal Education	
Elementary School	9 (23%)
High School	10 (26%)
College/Trade School	15 (38%)
Unknown	4 (10%)
No School	1 (3%)
Primary Language Spoken	
English	1 (2%)
Spanish	19 (49%)
Both	16 (41%)
Unknown	3 (8%)



Discussion & Conclusions

Numbers of interested, eligible parents who participated in the study provides insight into the acceptability and effectiveness of the study's recruitment efforts with Twin Cities' Latino parents of adolescents

To gain truthful opinions from a diverse group of parents, the research team had to:

1. **Recognize challenges and barriers that can affect participation** → immigration, legal status, location of focus groups, not knowing other participants, work and childcare issues, risk of "socially desirable" responses to sensitive topic
2. **Develop strategies to address these barriers** → clarifying that participation is voluntary, holding discussions at well-known cultural centers with easy access to public transportation, asking parents to invite others who were eligible to participate, providing a meal to create a supportive social environment, providing childcare and cash incentive, utilizing same-gender Latino facilitators, setting "ground rules" – information shared in group is private and confidential, asking parents to share opinions *vs.* personal experiences, letting parents know that their opinions are valued

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